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How to See

When you look at an image, you should start by looking at its composition – what is being shown and how. This means you pay attention to the objects and subjects, and how they are framed and focused upon.

Good image evaluation starts with consistent observation — not taste. Two annotators looking at the same image should notice the same things, even if they weigh them differently.

The goal is to replace "looks good" or "feels off" with specific, observable claims.

Style first, then these checks

The checks below are written for **photographic** prompts. When a prompt asks for a non-photo style — illustration, cartoon, 3D, diagram — don't treat "not photorealistic" as a flaw. Judge whether the image holds together *within that style*; photographic cues like depth of field and photographic lighting may not apply. AI tells — garbled text, broken hands, melted features — still count regardless of style.

Composition & framing

Composition is how the elements of an image are arranged. When evaluating, ask:

- **Subject placement** — is the main subject clearly positioned, or competing for attention with other elements?
- **Framing scale** — does the shot distance (wide, medium, close-up) match what the prompt asked for?
- **Visual hierarchy** — what draws your eye first? Does it match the intended focus?
- **Negative space** — is the area around the subject intentional breathing room, or empty and unresolved?



Same photo, side by side — with the rule-of-thirds grid overlaid you can see how the subject lines up on the intersections rather than dead center.

Notice that on the right, the rock is positioned on the left gridline. When you think of composition, you should understand that photographers generally try to use a 3 by 3 grid to compose images. The rule of thirds is a composition guideline that places your subject in the left or right third of an image, leaving the other two thirds more open.

Notice that the right image evokes more vastness and space, even though technically, it's simply a different crop of the same image.

A composition doesn't have to follow textbook rules — but it should look purposeful, not accidental.

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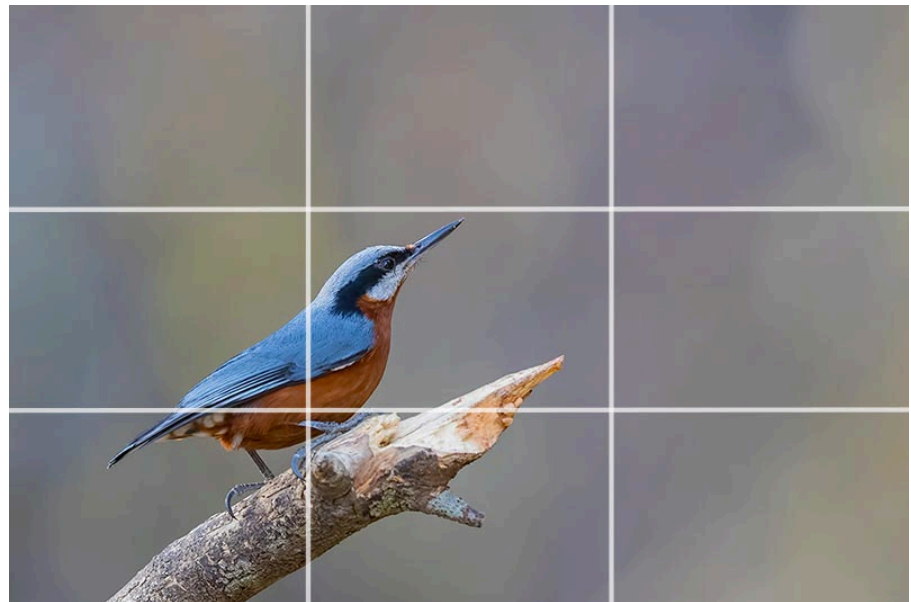
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The subject sits at a rule-of-thirds intersection rather than dead center — creating tension and directing the eye naturally across the frame.

Notice that the bird is sitting at the intersection point of two lines, directing the eye's attention there, and creating a composition and a beautiful image.

Want a deeper look at the rule of thirds and why composition matters? Start with these:

- [Adobe — The Rule of Thirds in Photography](#)
- [Wikipedia — Rule of thirds](#)

Focus, detail & clarity

Blur is not always a flaw

Shallow depth of field (blurred background, sharp subject) is a legitimate photographic choice. The question is whether the blur is intentional and consistent — not whether it exists.

- **Sharpness** — is the intended subject in focus? Check edges and fine details (hair strands, eyelashes, text).
- **Depth of field** — does the blur fall off naturally from the focal point, or does it appear in patches with no logic?
- **Compression and detail loss** — is fine detail (fabric weave, skin pores, grass blades) present where the image resolution should support it? Or is the image mushy in ways that look like generation failure rather than artistic choice?

The same scene shot at a wide aperture vs. a narrow one — the only thing that changes is how much of the frame is in sharp focus. Drag the handle to move between the two:

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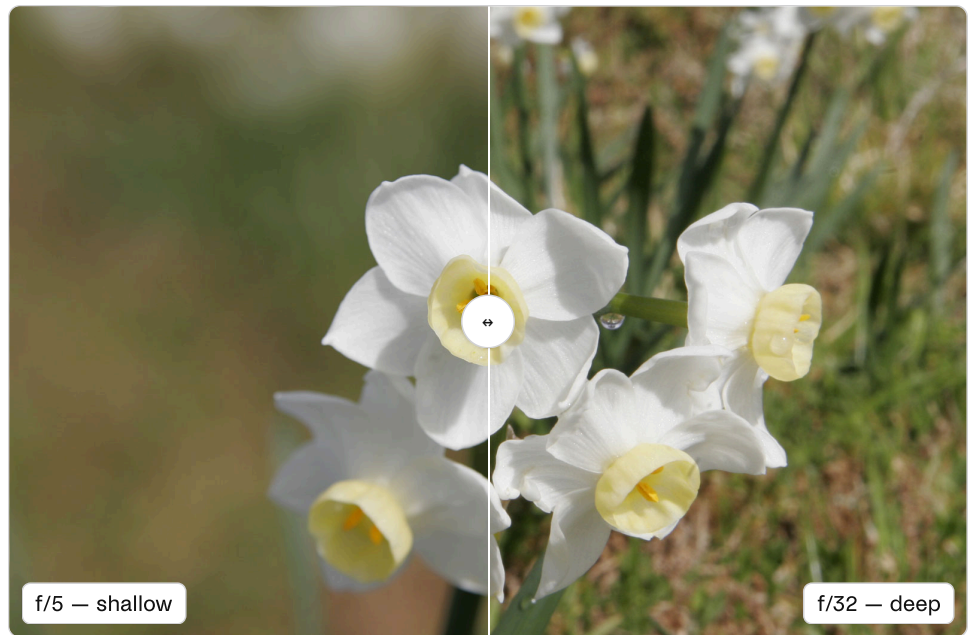
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Notice how the background is blurred at f/5? This is a shallow depth of field and wider aperture.

At shallow depth of field (wide aperture, low f-number), only the subject is in focus and the background dissolves into soft blur — the photographer's choice to isolate the subject. At deep depth of field (narrow aperture, high f-number), near and far elements are all sharp at once — typical of landscape or product photography where context matters.



Same portrait, same lighting — only the aperture changed. f/2 isolates the subject; f/22 keeps the whole forest sharp.

When you're judging an AI image, pay attention to how the photo shows the background. If the background is blurred, this might be a shallow depth of field photo. In that case, you would expect more light on the subject and generally more detail. However, this is not a hard rule—lighting is complex. In many AI-generated photos, the background is **unnaturally** sharp or unevenly focused. As you continue annotating, you will get a sense of this distinction.

Light & color

Light is the most common source of inconsistency in AI-generated images. Train yourself to check these independently:

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What to check	What to look for
Light source direction	Do shadows fall consistently from one source? Is the light hitting faces, objects, and background from the same angle?
Softness	Harsh light (direct sun) produces sharp, defined shadows. Diffused light (overcast, studio) produces soft edges. Does the shadow quality match the apparent source?
Contrast	Are highlights blown (pure white with no detail) or shadows crushed (pure black)?
Color temperature	Is the image consistently warm (golden, amber) or cool (blue, gray)? Mixed temperatures across a single scene are a red flag unless the lighting scenario explains it.
Saturation	Is color intensity consistent across the image, or do some regions look over-processed while others are flat?

Saturation should stay believable too. When color intensity is pushed past what the scene would naturally show, it doesn't just look off — it can bury real detail.



On the right, the image is oversaturated — the cranked colors obscure detail in the clouds, while the left keeps the tonal range that lets the cloud structure read.

Quick check

An annotator writes "this image looks good" about a landscape where the subject sits dead center with large, empty space on both sides. What is a stronger, more observable note?

"It feels balanced and pleasing to look at."

"The subject sits dead center with empty thirds on both sides; the framing reads as accidental rather than purposeful."

"The composition breaks the rule of thirds, so it is wrong."



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Check answer

A subject is sharp while the background dissolves into soft blur, and the blur falls off smoothly from the focal plane. How should you read this?

An AI artifact — real photos should be sharp across the whole frame.

Likely an intentional shallow depth of field, not a flaw.

A lighting inconsistency, since blurred areas receive less light.

Check answer

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